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Also impacting the U.S. population distribution is the fact that younger Americans (referred to as "millennials," born roughly between 1982 and 2004) are delaying marriage and children more so than any preceding generation, resulting in declining U.S. fertility rates. Figure 1 compares the U.S. population pyramid in 2000 to a projected population pyramid in 2030.

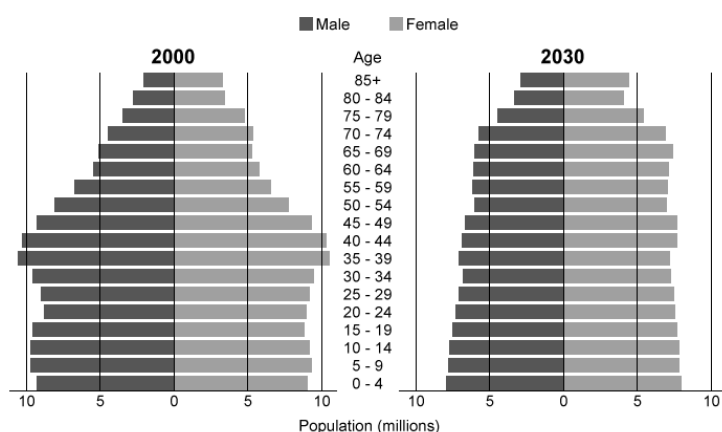


Figure 1 United States population pyramid from 2000 and a projected population pyramid for 2030

The description of baby boomers in the second paragraph best aligns with which sociological approach to aging?

- ☐ A. Continuity [22%]
- ☐ B. Activity [6%]
- ✔ ☒ C. Life course [60%]
- ☐ D. Disengagement [10%]

Correct

60% answered correctly

Explanation:

Major sociological approaches to aging	
Activity	Remaining physically & socially active improves quality of life for older adults
Continuity	Older adults attempt to maintain the habits & behaviors from their youth
Disengagement	Older adults withdraw from social relationships/society as society withdraws from them
Life course	Aging viewed holistically in terms of social, biological, cultural & psychological contexts

Aging involves biological, psychological, and social processes. Biologically, aging is characterized by decreased metabolism, a reduced ability for cells to repair and self-regulate, and impaired tissue and organ function. These biological changes impact individuals psychologically (eg, mood) and socially (eg, social status).

There are several sociological theories on aging. The **life course approach** is holistic and **multidisciplinary**, conceptualizing aging in

terms of **psychological, biological, and sociocultural** factors **across a lifetime**. This approach emphasizes the reciprocal link between social context and individuals as they age. In other words, aging individuals *influence and are influenced by* the broader contexts in which they live (society, history, the economy).

The passage describes the aging of baby boomers as having "social and historical significance" and describes the social and economic impacts of this aging cohort on society. Therefore, the description of the baby boomers in the second paragraph most closely aligns with the life course approach to aging.

(Choice A) The continuity approach to aging suggests that people attempt to maintain (or continue) the same habits and lifestyle as when they were younger. The second paragraph does not discuss aging at a micro level, as individuals attempting to maintain life continuity.

(Choice B) The activity approach to aging suggests that the transition to old age is eased by remaining physically active (eg, exercise) and socially involved (eg, community engagement). The second paragraph does not discuss activity or engagement of baby boomers as they age.

(Choice D) Disengagement theory, a negative approach to aging, holds that there is a mutual withdrawal between aging individuals and society. The second paragraph makes no mention of how the oldest baby boomers are withdrawing from society.

Educational objective:

The life course approach to aging is holistic, taking into account psychological, social, biological, and cultural factors across a lifetime. Other aging theories focus on the extent to which older adults remain active (activity theory), continue their regular habits and relationships (continuity theory), or withdraw from society (disengagement theory).

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400801
System:
Demographics and Social Structure

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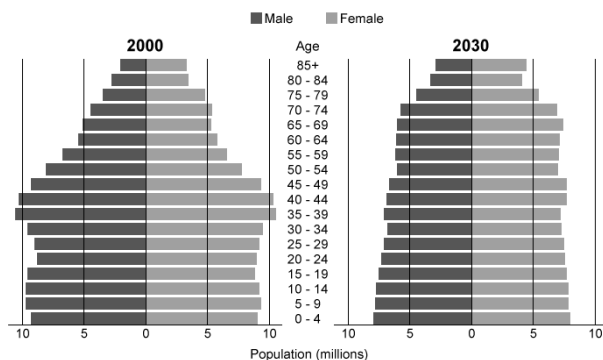


Figure 1 United States population pyramid from 2000 and a projected population pyramid for 2030

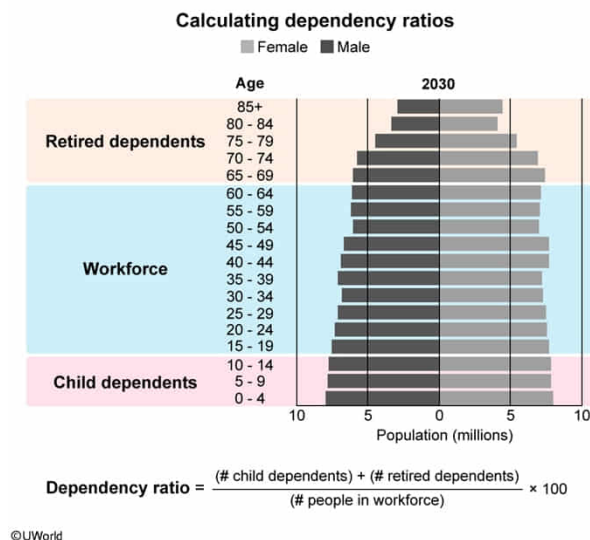
Which of the following would increase the dependency ratio in 2030?

- ✓ ☒ A. Millennials have more children than expected. [69%]
- ☐ B. Unemployment rates are lower than expected. [7%]
- ☐ C. Mortality rates for baby boomers are higher than expected. [12%]
- ☐ D. The retirement age changes from 65 to 75. [10%]

Correct

70% answered correctly

Explanation:



The **dependency ratio** is the **proportion of unproductive** (ie, too old or too young to work) to **productive** (ie, working-age) members in a society. People under the age of 15 and over the age 64 are considered too young and too old, respectively, to have jobs and contribute to the economy. The dependency ratio is a rough estimate based on age, calculated by adding the number of people below age 15 and above age 64 and dividing that sum by the number of people age 15-64. The resulting fraction is then multiplied by 100 to obtain the number of dependents per 100 people of working age.

As the ratio increases, there is more pressure on the productive members of society to support and care for children and the elderly. If millennials have more children than expected, this would increase (not decrease) the dependency ratio because it would result in an **increase** in the number of children who are too young to work.

(Choice B) Strictly speaking, dependency ratios do not take unemployment rates into account. They are very crude measures based on the number of people in each age cohort (used as an estimation of who is and is not employed). However, if the unemployment rate is lower than expected, the calculated number of people in the work force (denominator) would increase, causing the dependency ratio to **decline**.

(Choice C) If mortality rates for baby boomers are higher than expected, the calculated number of retired dependents (numerator) would decrease, causing the dependency ratio to **decline**.

(Choice D) If the retirement age changes from 65 to 75, the number of people in the work force (denominator) would increase and the number of retired dependents (numerator) would decrease, causing the dependency ratio to **decline**.

Educational objective:

The dependency ratio is the ratio of the number of dependents (people age 0-14 and 65+) to the number of productive members in a society, given as a rough estimate.

The higher the dependency ratio, the more pressure there is on working-age members of society to support dependents.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400802

System:
Demographics and Social Structure

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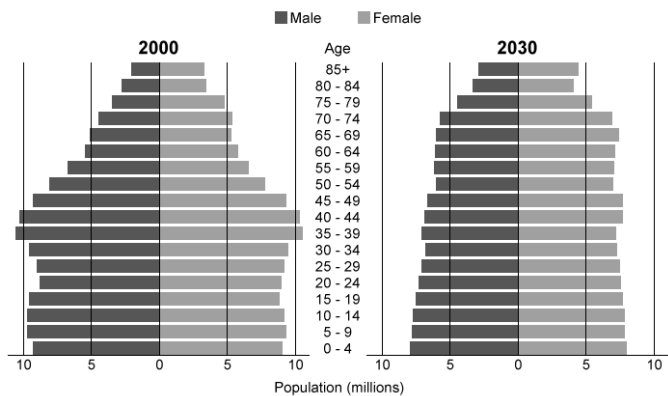


Figure 1 United States population pyramid from 2000 and a projected population pyramid for 2030

Based on the information in the passage, a conflict theorist would suggest that the social significance of aging in America is best demonstrated by:

- ☐ A. changing conceptions of "old age" as people live longer. [4%]
- ☐ B. the relationship between doctors and their aging patients. [1%]
- ☐ C. medicalization of aging by the medical and insurance industries. [6%]
- ✔ ☒ D. competition between generations for the allocation of resources. [88%]

Correct

88% answered correctly

Explanation:

Major theoretical approaches to sociology			
Theory	Description	Perspective	Theorists
Functionalism	- Society = an organism - Each part of society works to maintain dynamic equilibrium (homeostasis)	Macro	Émile Durkheim, Talcott Parsons
Conflict	- Society = struggle for limited resources - Inequality based on social class	Macro	Karl Marx, Max Weber
Social constructionism	- Social actors define what is real - Knowledge about world based on interactions	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)
Symbolic interactionism	- Meaning & value attached to symbols - Individual interactions based on these symbols	Micro	Charles Cooley, George Herbert Mead
Rational choice/social exchange	Individual behaviors & interactions attempt to maximize personal gain & minimize personal cost	Micro	(Not critical for exam)
Feminist	Examines gender inequality in society	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)

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The **social significance** of aging is reflected in how different societies **treat** and **define aging**. For example, many Asian societies value the wisdom of age over youth, whereas in Western society youth is highly valued. Expected behaviors corresponding to life stages may also vary. For example, in some societies children routinely contribute to their families by engaging in manual or other paid labor, whereas in Western society children typically do not.

Conflict theory is a macro-sociological perspective that focuses on the behavior of social groups rather than the behavior of individuals. According to **conflict theory**, conflict arises when resources, such as wealth and power, are **unequally distributed** throughout a **society**. Conflict theory predicts that class conflict results from members of the highest social classes possessing most of the resources compared to members of the lower classes.

The passage describes the potential economic impact of providing medical and social care to aging baby boomers. A conflict theorist would most likely emphasize that this *competition between generations* for the allocation of limited resources defines the social significance of aging in America.

(Choice A) A social constructionist would be more likely to focus on age as a social construct. Therefore, a constructionist (not a conflict theorist) would emphasize how conceptions of "old age" change as people live longer.

(Choice B) As a macro-sociological perspective, conflict theory seldom assesses individual interactions between people, such as between doctor and patient.

(Choice C) The medicalization of aging by the medical and insurance industries is a potential topic for a conflict theorist, but only as it relates to the uneven distribution of or competition for limited resources.

Educational objective:

Social significance of aging describes how age is treated and defined in society, and expectations associated with age. Conflict theory is a macro-sociological perspective focusing on how the unequal distribution of resources in society leads to conflict between groups.

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400803
System:
Demographics and Social Structure

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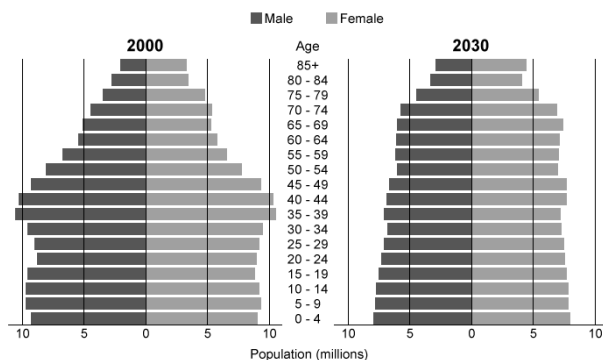


Figure 1 United States population pyramid from 2000 and a projected population pyramid for 2030

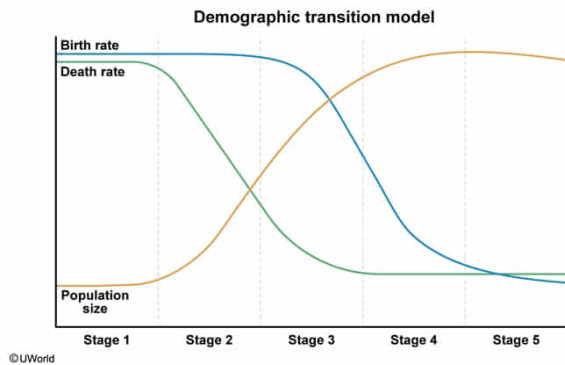
What model is being described in the first paragraph?

- ☐ A. Social exchange [1%]
- ☐ B. Optimum population [9%]
- ☐ C. Malthusian theory [11%]
- ☒ D. Demographic transition [78%]

Correct

78% answered correctly

Explanation:



The **demographic transition model** refers to the transition of a society from high birth and death rates to low birth and death rates. This transition typically occurs in predictable stages:

- Stage 1: In pre-industrial societies, birth and death rates are both high and population growth is slow.
- Stage 2: As society industrializes, death rates drop as food/medicine availability and sanitation increase.
- Stage 3: As society urbanizes, birth rates decline as access to contraception increases.
- Stage 4: In developed societies, birth and death rates are both low and population growth is slow.
- Stage 5: Hypothetically, for developed societies with very low birth rates, population may decline.

The first paragraph most aligns with the demographic transition model as it describes declining death rates, increased population size, and declining birth rates as the United States transitioned from a pre-industrial society to a modern one.

(Choice A) Social exchange theory describes human interaction as resulting from people's perceptions of what they invest in a relationship and what they get out of it. This is not described in the first paragraph.

(Choice B) Optimum population is a demographic theory regarding the ideal population size, which is the number of people yielding the highest per capita income given the country's level of wealth, knowledge, and technical resources. This is not addressed in the first paragraph.

(Choice C) Malthusian theory maintains that population growth is exponential but resource growth is linear. When populations outgrow available resources, preventive checks decrease the birth rate and positive checks increase the death rate; Malthusian catastrophes are large-scale positive checks (war, disease epidemics). This is not what is being described in the first paragraph.

Educational objective:

According to demographic transition theory, societies progress through stages marked by characteristic changes in birth rate, death rate, and population size. Stage 1 has high birth/death rates and small population size; stage 2 has a declining death rate and increasing population size; stage 3 has declining birth rates; stage 4 has low birth/death rates; and stage 5 has a declining population size.

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

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System:
Demographics and Social Structure

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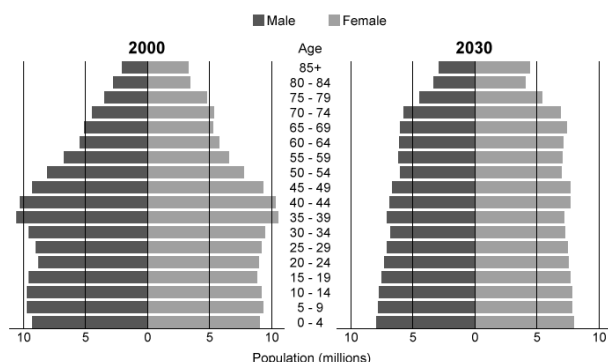


Figure 1 United States population pyramid from 2000 and a projected population pyramid for 2030

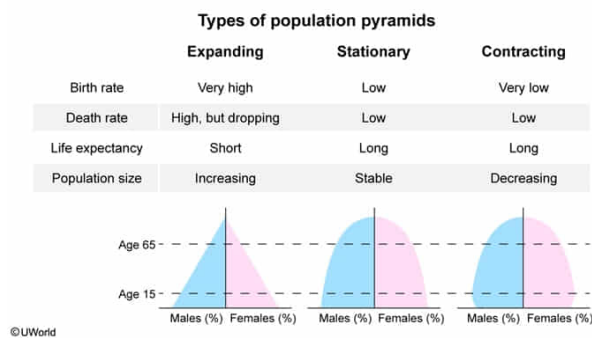
Based on Figure 1, which of the following is predicted to decrease by 2030?

- ☐ A. Life expectancy [2%]
- ☐ B. Mortality rate [28%]
- ☒ C. Population size [52%]
- ☐ D. Median age [15%]

Correct

53% answered correctly

Explanation:



Population pyramids depict a given population by **age cohort** (those born within a specified time frame) and gender, displaying the relative number of males and females in each age category. There are three general population pyramid shapes: expanding, stationary, and contracting.

Expanding pyramids have broad bases (lots of younger people) and narrow tops (few older people) and are characteristic of developing countries in the early stages of demographic transition, with high birth/death rates and increasing population sizes. **Stationary** pyramids have broad bases and tops and are characteristic of developed countries in the later stages of demographic transition, with low birth/death rates and stable population sizes. **Contracting** pyramids have narrower bases than middles and are characteristic of developed countries in the final stage of demographic transition, with very low birth rates and a gradually declining population size.

In Figure 1, the 2000 population pyramid resembles a cross between stationary (bottom half) and expanding (top half), whereas the 2030 projected population pyramid is stationary. The large number of people in their 30s and 40s in 2000 are not being replaced, so it appears the *population size will decrease by 2030*.

(Choice A) In 2030, there are more individuals in the 60 and older age cohorts than in 2000. Therefore, compared with 2000, life expectancy (the average number of years people are expected to live) is predicted to either *increase* or remain roughly the same in 2030.

(Choice B) With more individuals in the 60 and older age cohorts in 2030 compared with 2000, the mortality (death) rate is predicted to either increase or remain roughly the same in 2030.

(Choice D) In 2000, the number of middle-aged people was greater than the number of children. Between 2000 and 2030, the number of births appears to drop.

so the median age will *increase* as the surplus of middle-aged people in 2000 ages and will not be counterbalanced by young people.

Educational objective:

A population pyramid is a type of bar graph that depicts the number or percentage of men and women in certain age brackets in a given population. Expanding pyramids show more young than old, stationary pyramids show stable populations, and contracting pyramids reflect gradually declining populations.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400805

System:
Demographics and Social Structure

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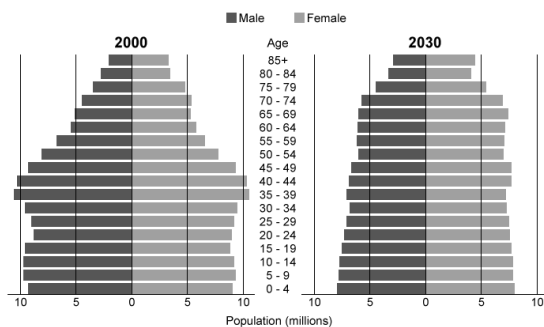


Figure 1 United States population pyramid from 2000 and a projected population pyramid for 2030

The passage provides specific data for which of the following in the United States?

- ☐ A. The number of live births per year for every 1,000 members of a population, regardless of sex or age [7%]
- ☐ B. The total number of live births per year for every 1,000 women of childbearing age in a population [10%]
- ☒ C. The average number of children born per woman during her lifetime [75%]
- ☐ D. The number of live births per year for 1,000 women in a certain age group in a population [6%]

Correct

76% answered correctly

Explanation:

The **fertility rate** is a measure of the number of people being added to a given population through birth (as opposed to immigration). There are multiple ways demographers express fertility (or birth) rates.

Total fertility rate (TFR) is the average number of children born per woman during her lifetime. For example, in 1955 (the middle of the "baby boom") the TFR in the U.S. was 3.6 children per woman, whereas in 2012 the TFR was 1.8. For a population to remain constant without immigration, the TFR must be 2 (referred to as the replacement rate), which is the number required to replace the two individuals required to create the two children. A TFR above 2 means the population is growing and below 2, that it is shrinking.

The passage provides *specific data for TFR only* because it mentions the number of births *per woman* is about two (Paragraph 1).

(Choice A) The **crude birth rate** (CBR) is the number of live births per year for every 1,000 members of a population, regardless of sex or age. An underdeveloped country may have a CBR of 50, whereas a more developed country may have a CBR of 10. CBR is used as a rough estimate of population growth through birth only. The last paragraph mentions birth rates declining, but does not provide any numbers (no specific data for CBR).

(Choice B) Demographers more commonly use the **general fertility rate** (GFR), the total number of live births per year for every 1,000 women *of childbearing age* in a population, which is a better measure of fertility than the CBR because it accounts for the age distribution and sex ratio of the population. There are no specific data for GFR provided in the passage.

(Choice D) The **age-specific fertility rate** (ASFR) is the number of live births per year for 1,000 women in a certain age group in a population. For example, the ASFR per 1,000 women age 25–29 may be in the hundreds, whereas the ASFR per 1,000 women age 40–44 may be in the single digits. There are no specific data for ASFR provided in the passage.

Educational objective:

The crude birth rate refers to the number of live births per year for every 1,000 people in a population; the general fertility rate refers to the total number of live births per year for every 1,000 women of childbearing age; the total fertility rate refers to the average number of children born per woman during her lifetime. The age-specific fertility rate refers to the number of live births per year for every 1,000 women of a certain age group.

Time spent: 0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

QID: 400806

System:

Demographics and Social Structure